to look after me, dressing my wound and explaining that my slapstick needs a bit of work. It is all very regular teenage escapades, no one with much of an idea what we are doing or what our futures hold, just bundling ourselves from one moment to the next, only stopping to watch *Red Dwarf* or Lee Evans or Victoria Wood.

I balance this sort of new *joie de vivre* in some of these everyday 'teenager meets world' outings with a real ability to sulk on a cricket pitch when things aren't going my way. After all, I am still nowhere near the bowler or cricketer I want to be. It isn't offering me any realistic way out. I can't even get out of the thirds. When I bowl badly, I have, what the Burnley players call then, an 'absolute cob on' for hours. I just can't hide it. It becomes me. It feels like the world is closing in on me. All I want is for sport to go right, for the ball to bend to my will.

At Smackwater Jacks at the weekends, everyone from Burnley who is out is out there. It's divided into two floors and there is an unwritten rule for everyone. All the school kids and teenagers are on the first floor, and all the adults are on the ground floor. We are kicking our feet around on the first floor, fumbling our way around conversations, and Gaz says, 'Shall we see what the adults are doing?' They are all at least 15 years older than us, and yet, because they know us from the cricket club, they treat us like we are just with them. It's an access I wouldn't have without cricket and, on the ground floor of Smacks, I feel much more at home. There is no tension or hyper fixation on weaknesses or herd mentality, I just feel allowed to be myself here, whoever that is. Upstairs is full of people who think they're the big time, and I can't bear it. Cricket is not like that, I think to myself on this floor. It somehow carves people out, shapes them into an acceptance of themselves, settles them in their skin. Next stop, Panama Joe's. It's ten pence a pint there.

It was all so normal. We were all doing the same thing. Nothing in those summers, in all that messing around, all that longing, all that trying and failing, gave anyone the sense of what was to come knocking.